

Gesualdo / Take 6

Concert-conference for string quartet, AI, and impossible harmonies

Introduction

This concert-conference begins with a short four-voice piece played without a label. The audience is invited to hear it first as a question: Renaissance, Baroque, sacred, modern? The reveal is part of the argument: the piece is the Beach Boys' *Our Prayer*, and it already shows vocal harmony becoming quartet harmony.

The programme then places two distant vocal worlds beside one another: Carlo Gesualdo's late Renaissance madrigals and sacred music, and the dense, radiant close harmony of *Take 6*. Both repertoires are built from voices that move with extraordinary independence, but both also create moments where harmony seems to stop time: suspensions, chromatic shocks, luminous clusters, and unexpected resolutions.

The string quartet hears these works from inside. Instead of treating the quartet as a simple transcription machine, the project asks how five or six vocal lines can be reduced, redistributed, and made playable by four instruments while keeping as much of the original contrapuntal pressure as possible. This is also where AI enters the evening: as a tool for listening, searching, recombining, testing, and auditing musical decisions.

The programme moves from the four-voice opening into Gesualdo's five-voice madrigal world, then toward more extreme chromatic writing, then opens a modern mirror through *Take 6*. The six-voice Gesualdo near the end acts as a historical summit, and the final *Take 6* piece, *A Quiet Place*, gives the evening a calm landing after the harmonic vertigo.

Programme

#	Piece	Composer	Original	Approx.
1	Anonymous opening chorale	revealed later	4 voices	c. 1:10
2	Luci serene e chiare	Carlo Gesualdo	5 voices	c. 3:00
3	Dolcissima mia vita	Carlo Gesualdo	5 voices	c. 2:15
4	Gia piansi nel dolore	Carlo Gesualdo	5 voices	c. 2:40
5	S'io non miro non moro	Carlo Gesualdo	5 voices	c. 2:00
6	Come Unto Me	Take 6	6 vocal parts	c. 2:15
7	Moro, lasso, al mio duolo	Carlo Gesualdo	5 voices	c. 3:00
8	Sparge la morte	Carlo Gesualdo	5 voices	c. 2:50
9	Belta, poi che t'assenti	Carlo Gesualdo	5 voices	c. 2:15
10	Tristis est anima mea	Carlo Gesualdo	6 voices	c. 3:00
11	Hark! The Herald Angels Sing	Take 6	6 vocal parts	c. 2:30
12	A Quiet Place	Take 6	6 vocal parts	c. 2:45

Total music: approximately 29:30 strict timing, or about 32-33 minutes with stage pacing and transitions. The complete event can comfortably fit into a one-hour concert-conference with short spoken introductions between musical groups.

Suggested Spoken Arc

1. Opening question. Begin with the anonymous four-voice piece, then reveal the Beach Boys and use that surprise to introduce vocal harmony without voices.

2. Reduction as listening. How the quartet version compresses five or six voices into four instruments, and what has to be preserved: line, tension, register, and harmonic identity.

3. AI as a musical workbench. The system is not presented as a replacement composer, but as a way to inspect style, test constraints, locate problems, and generate musical alternatives.

4. The final turn. After Gesualdo's 6-voice sacred depth, Hark brings radiance and A Quiet Place closes the evening not with a demonstration, but with a destination.